



Lebanon

Once a vibrant cultural hotspot, Lebanon suffered badly from years of civil war and occupation until a 1989 peace deal. Reconstruction was reversed by Israeli bombardment in 2006.



GEOGRAPHY

Behind a narrow Mediterranean coastal plain, two parallel mountain ranges run the length of the country, separated by the fertile Beqaa Valley.



CLIMATE

Winters are mild and summers are hot, with high coastal humidity. Snow falls on high ground in winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Politics has long been dominated by divisions between Sunni and Shi'a Muslims and the traditional ruling Maronite Christians. Power-sharing ended 14 years of civil war in 1989. Syria acted as power broker until made to withdraw in 2005. Israel attacked in 2006 in a botched bid to crush Iranian-backed Hezbollah militants. A huge gulf exists between the poor and a small, immensely rich elite. Lebanon hosts 420,000 Palestinian refugees.



THE ECONOMY

Much infrastructure destroyed. Instability undermines Beirut's role as regional financial center. Wine and fruit production. High public debt.



INSIGHT: *The Cedar of Lebanon has been the nation's symbol for more than 2000 years*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Lebanon

DATE OF FORMATION: 1941

CAPITAL: Beirut

POPULATION: 4.22 million

TOTAL AREA: 4015 sq. miles
(10,400 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1069 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, French,
Armenian, Assyrian

RELIGIONS: Muslim 70%,
Christian 30%

ETHNIC MIX: Arab 94%, Armenian 4%,
other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Lebanese pound = 100 piastres